suggest their friendship is conditions-based or unreliable will reinforce this desire.

Indian policymakers and analysts, on their part, will have to realize that partners often have conditions or expectations, but it is important to distinguish between the strings that establish lines of connection and those that are chains of control. Moreover, it is crucial to remember that for security and economic objectives, Indian governments have accepted "strings" in the past, including in 1962–1963, when Nehru assured the US and Pakistan that India would only use American military aid against China, and in 1971, when India committed to a whole range of obligations to the Soviet Union when they signed a treaty. And various Indian governments and their American counterparts tempered criticism of each other when they found the US-India relationship to be crucial for their broader strategic purposes. It is also important for Indian observers to recognize that external partnerships and internal capacity building are not mutually exclusive—the first can, and indeed should, facilitate the latter. Finally, the idea behind diversification was to create flexibility; treating it—and strategic autonomy—as a rigid doctrine defeats that very purpose and ties policymakers' hands. When policymakers did so, for example in the 1950s, it contributed to leaving India unprepared against China.

Nonalignment Does Not Mean No Alignment

Indian diversification, as this book shows, has not been of the hub-and-spoke variety—that is, all countries have not been kept equidistant, and bilateral relationships have not been treated equally. At different times, India has had closer relationships with some countries—the degree of closeness has been determined by, among other things, the level of importance of the other country, India's priorities and needs at the time, the willingness of the other country to engage with India, and India's other options in terms of partners. Diversification has not precluded alignment toward certain countries when the circumstances call for it—in fact, it makes alignment possible.

Alliances might be anathema to India, but alignment is not. This book shows that India's decisionmakers have had to move away from their instinct to diversify and significantly increase dependence on one partner or